

AP

BREAKING GROUND TMC chief Mamata Banerjee after taking oath of office as the first woman CM of West Bengal in Kolkata, May 2011

The decade marked a decisive shift in Indian politics, one in which regional leaders stopped behaving like provincial satraps and began acting as national power centres. This was not merely a story of coalition arithmetic. It was a deeper transformation in which states became the primary theatres of political legitimacy, leadership experiments and social coalitions, often leaving Delhi reacting rather than directing.

Nitish Kumar was among the earliest symbols of this change. In Bihar, long dismissed as ungovernable, he recast governance as a political ideology. Roads, schools and electricity became electoral weapons, and law and order a moral argument. Nitish's appeal lay in presenting development as social justice without the rhetoric of permanent grievance. His success demonstrated that caste politics could be reordered without being abandoned, a lesson that resonated well beyond Bihar and unsettled the Congress's assumption that national narratives automatically translated into state victories.

TMC chief Mamata Banerjee's rise in West Bengal was more visceral and disruptive. She did not merely defeat the Left's 34-year rule; she dismantled an entire political culture. Her politics thrived on



▲ Dec. 5, 2005



▲ Apr. 2, 2012

The Long Runners

Nitish Kumar first became Bihar's chief minister in 2005, rebuilding a broken state through governance-led politics while positioning himself nationally as a credible, secular alternative within coalition arithmetic, often shaping Centre–state equations during the UPA years. Mamata Banerjee took charge of West Bengal in 2011, toppling the Left's 34-year rule and quickly emerging as a formidable national player whose parliamentary numbers and street credibility repeatedly constrained the UPA's reform agenda. Between them, they embodied a shift in national politics where durable state power translated into leverage over Delhi, making regional leaders indispensable to governance at the Centre.